

Whalesing Because You Have a Whalesong

Big Hank washed ashore sometime last week. There was a big fuss about the whole thing, even though we've had dead whales before. When venerable creatures die, you can't *not* have a fuss. Spiritually they deserve respect; no matter how bad they smell. Anyway, the scientists came along, wearing shell jackets and hiking shoes that left heeled prints in the sand, and cut him open. Left his intestines to spill out like spaghetti. If they hadn't done so, the methane in his stomach would've pressed and pressed until he spewed a giant sea of red, grey, black. Divine rainbow mayhem.

Have you ever seen a grey whale? Great sight. Their fins come up like little hands waving hello, and despite their mass, they breach through the water as if surface tension is but a dream. People dream up mermaids and sirens while grey whales are *right there*. Whales house barnacles, stabilise the marine ecosystem, and fertilise phytoplankton without much ado. Sirens impose themselves on folklore, but that's really it. They're much too human and violent for eco-benefit. Maybe sailors mistook seaweed-covered whales for sirens, so on and so forth, leading to a gross misrepresentation of beauty in the hydrosphere.

Big Hank was a citizen. Not a siren. One with the sand and featureless sky, he was perfect right there; on that specific stretch bordered by grey, knifelike rocks. I remember looking down my galoshes at his mouth, slightly ajar, and scars, these bits of white that made him more of a cow than a 'grey'; wondering whether whales went to Heaven or began planning their explosions right away. Ancient things like him deserve revenge, especially when anthropogenic bullshit cuts their wisdom for no good reason.

His revenge came in the form of dumpster death. Decaying people smell terrible, but whales take the cake. Bacteria multiplies and begins waging an anarchic coup over the body wherein it functioned, eating up like a hungry dog on a dead owner's corpse. Minus the desperation and plus the biological necessity. If humans hold colonies, then whales hold an entire planet.

What I find interesting, though, isn't Big Hank himself (sorry, Hank) or his smelly significance. We lived in a remote, tight-knit sort of place, and the great change that washed over whenever a whale passed was *palpable*. Palpable as in touchable, audible, regretfully sniffable. Nothing much to see besides fields and dogs and gently ridged roofs; modular architecture right on the cusp of the changing, turning shore.

Big Hank's death brought a new dimension to life. The kids explored and braved his stench just fine, especially motivated by sensible people saying, "Bears will get to that". Hell, he was the land's greatest scene for miles around. While the scientists rolled away to discuss the logistics of hauling him out or whether they should let our cabal of cultish villagers celebrate him instead, plans roared. Bonfires, walks at a safe distance, and even picnics brought many a brave soul to the beach. Folks usually sat on the other side, hoping Big Hank's wind wouldn't hit them, but always positioned themselves so that he was in view.

When the sun set, his form lay still and constant. Nobody expected him to move. Imagine a mountain— a piece of land that you'd live with rather than marvel at— and add some quirkiness to the thought. Big Hank was a mountain.

Most people couldn't handle his rotten corpse turn-off unless they wore nose plugs. The wound inflicted by four brave scientists was especially bad. I now wonder why they didn't just, you know, poke holes and let the gas escape from those, but at the time we were all convinced of their authority. They probably wanted tissue samples and hit him with a double whammy.

By "we", I mean the village. It feels like a crime to divorce anyone specific from the "we". We moved as a collective. When the aforementioned brave souls came out to party, we followed. We became a "we" again, revelled in the uniting, and by several tricks of the eye, our limited teenage population made Big Hank's corpse a spot.

Spot is slang for entertainment hub, I think? They went to take some pictures and hung around the general area until nicer, shinier things caught their eyes. During the sliver of time where *everyone* worshipped whale guts, I watched them move like nature-doc tigers. Unfortunately, my observations were wrong. My friend, much closer to social life, told me one particular bit that changed the idea of humans' proximity to tigers, whales, the lot. She told me about a grey sky and odd undoing.

Right around the period where Big Hank's decomposition picked up and the villagers accepted his permanent place in life, she and another friend went to visit him. Maybe as a goodbye, because she was off to the mainland for college and the friend was off to somewhere even greater. Laughing about village conventions and how, jeez, whales won't ever show up where we're going, they sat down by the sandy hill overlooking his corpse and missed everything before it left.

She was off for marine biology. So I presume there was a lot of talk about microbes and science, what makes a whale a whale. Humans share 65% of our DNA with whales, yet we look nothing like them, and the reason comes down to basic genetics. By all the old laws of science, humans should be rational creatures, yet we're not. We admire dead animals like gods, paying homage to what we killed with fertilisers and plastic, then come around to kissing friends on the whale-watching hill. The kissing bit was strange. When she told it to me first, I looked over her shoulder and frowned.

I'm a little better about it now. Looking back on the unofficial Big Hank festival, nothing made sense; and because nothing did, absurdity in the face of rot wasn't too unusual. If Big Hank could speak, he might've even thought, as his great grey head broke the waves of whale-afterlife, *these people love me. They love novelty, and they love me.*

Whales and scientists and villagers make little sense alone, but I see them together clear as day.